

Ghana's Expanded Inshore Exclusion Zone (IEZ)

27TH April, 2026

What it means and why it matters

The Inshore Exclusion Zone

Ghana's Inshore Exclusion Zone (IEZ) is a designated coastal area reserved primarily for artisanal (small-scale) fishers, where industrial fishing vessels, large semi-industrial vessels and canoe support vessels are prohibited for fishing or fishing-related activities.

Under Ghana's current Fisheries and Aquaculture Act, 2025 (Act 1146), the IEZ has been expanded from 6 to 12 nautical miles (11 to 22 kilometers) off the coast.

This means that industrial fishing vessels are now restricted further offshore, leaving a larger nearshore area reserved for artisanal fishers.



Why This Matters

The IEZ expansion holds particular significance for fisheries management and ocean governance in Ghana:

1. It helps protect coastal livelihoods by reducing competition between industrial trawlers and artisanal fishers, thereby safeguarding incomes, especially for women involved in fish processing and trade.
2. It supports the recovery of fish stocks by protecting critical nearshore breeding and nursery habitats, contributing to the rebuilding of declining small pelagic species.
3. It strengthens ocean governance by promoting more equitable access to marine resources, aligning with sustainable blue economy principles, and reinforcing efforts to combat illegal, unreported, and unregulated (IUU) fishing.



Where WASMaN Fits In

The expansion of Ghana's IEZ is a bold and necessary step toward sustainable fisheries and fair resource use. Its success will depend on people, participation, and partnerships, in addition to policy.

WASMaN has a critical role to play in ensuring that this reform is inclusive, evidence-based, and impactful for women and coastal communities especially. WASMaN members are encouraged to:

1. Engage in community awareness efforts.
2. Track and share local observations and insights, including impacts on women's livelihoods.
3. Support community-based reporting of illegal fishing activities.